

Divesting from Big Tech: Alternative possibilities for research and futuring in social computing

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ABSTRACT

The CSCW community's research has traditionally supported by large technology companies such as Google, Meta, or Microsoft. This is not only limited to financial support: our sites of research and our design initiatives have also traditionally included these large corporations, their platforms, and their services. This panel brings together people working on questions of social computing and distributed collaboration outside of Big Tech companies—whether by fostering community work and activism, crafting legislation, seeking alternative funding streams, leading unionization or federated ventures, or promoting alternative ways of interacting digitally. Panelists will consider how CSCW research can and should consider alternative sources of support and sites of influence, how imbrication with specific technologies developed by Google, Meta or Twitter has shaped our findings about "social" technologies, issues in system design and maintenance outside of the Big Tech ecosystem, how to engage with regulatory stakeholders to enact change, and how to work productively outside of platform capitalism. With increasing public concern over the power of large technology companies and public gaffes with respect to once-trusted corporate infrastructures, the panelists show what we gain and lose analytically, practically, and in terms of sociotechnical futuring when CSCW practitioners look beyond the Big Tech ecosystem.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Human-centered computing** → **Computer supported cooperative work**.

KEYWORDS

Big Tech, divestment, alternative technologies

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1 OVERVIEW AND RELEVANCE

CSCW community members receive a tremendous amount of support from large technology companies. Corporations such as Microsoft, IBM, Google, and Meta are premier sponsors of our conferences. Support from the NSF in cyberinfrastructure research has recently been augmented with material support from Amazon¹. A vast number of papers published at our conferences examine how people interact on social platforms developed and owned by large companies, from Instagram and WhatsApp to Twitter and Snap. Prized internships, doctoral fellowships, and visiting faculty opportunities dot the professional C.V.'s in the field. And many CSCW researchers have successfully influenced product development at these corporations by bringing insights from our scholarship to the table—including ethical questions and concerns [10, 21].

Certainly, CSCW is not alone in its embrace of the academic-industry partnership: a transition taking place at universities and research institutes for over twenty years [4]. Other academic communities have fostered connections with significant industrial funders, with concerns about the ethics and outcomes of research [16]. Yet this imbrication has gone largely unquestioned at CSCW in terms of how it directs our scholarly attention, our insights, and our potential to create change. Few papers study systems outside of these large ecosystems at all [8, 20]. Fewer still address the ways in which these industry connections shape their research questions and publications, or how we might imagine alternative systems and practices.

Recent events, however, have raised an alarm. Elon Musk's 2022 acquisition of Twitter prompted a significant change in how this platform (once considered among researchers to be something of a "public good" infrastructure essential to human challenges such as disaster management, public information, civic voice, and protest) is both used and perceived. Social media technologies' racist undertones have been well documented and are increasingly widely known [3, 14, 15], as are concerns about mental health online, harassment, and the expansion of "surveillance capitalism" [23]. Meanwhile, large companies like Google and Meta have fired key employees in their ethics departments, even as their troublesome "A.I." products have flooded the Internet in an attempt to capture a nascent market. White collar employees at many Big Tech companies are also demanding unionization and a voice in the direction of their firm. And federal agencies in the E.U., the United States, and elsewhere are turning their attention to reining in the tech giants through regulation about privacy, harassment, and data management.

¹For instance, work on fairness in AI: <https://new.nsf.gov/news/nsf-amazon-continue-collaboration-strengthens>

In response, a growing number of social computing researchers within and beyond academia identify as industry-independent. These scholars take a variety of standpoints, situating themselves as collaborators with community activists, or as impartial experts, or policy enforcers, or informants to strategic litigation. Drawing from the history and philosophy of science, these scholars have published research on the influence of technology industry on research [5, 19], built explicitly industry-independent research labs [10], created new publications and fellowship programs,² developed institutional protections from industry capture within scholarly societies [22], and created new organizations to advance, support, and defend independent research on technology and society [13].

Still, many questions face CSCW researchers as we look beyond Big Tech for support and engagement. Corporate research departments do much of the infrastructuring labor for research continuity and engagement with communities of practice, leading to questions of necessary support over the long term that can also uphold parallel goals, for instance toward diversity in science [11]. Still, many CSCW scholars and community workers alike reach for the ready-access tools of Big Tech to scaffold their collaborative work, from Google Docs to Amazon Web Services [9, 18], despite the fact that such platforms are not neutral and beg alternatives. Industry-independent researchers face unique risks, and their freedom to perform public-interest work may inspire opposition from corporate interests. And while industry-independent platforms offer opportunities for anti-capitalist or anti-racist work [1, 6], they can also become a quagmire for harassment, inequity, and homophily. The question of remaining oriented toward justice in systems with non-corporate accountability and diverse participation is therefore an open one. Along the way, there is much to learn from social movements both within and outside of Big Tech as they innovate for change and connection.

With increasing public concern over the power of large technology companies and public gaffes with respect to once-trusted corporate infrastructures, and increasing interest at CSCW in alternative streams of research and funding, this panel aims to uncover what we gain and lose analytically, practically, and in terms of sociotechnical futuring when CSCW practitioners engage outside the Big Tech ecosystem. We invite CSCW scholars to consider rising alternatives to the Big Tech-Academic partnership model, and to more thoroughly address what such opportunities offer for our scholarship and our community of practice. The panel brings together people working on the study of digital systems outside of Big Tech companies: by fostering community work and activism, seeking alternative funding streams, leading unionization or federated ventures, developing industry-independent models of research [2, 12], crafting governance or legislative regulations, or promoting alternative ways of interacting digitally. Panelists will consider how CSCW can and should consider alternative sources of support and sites of influence, how our research entanglement with specific technologies developed by growth-oriented firms have shaped our findings about "social" technologies, and how to work productively and with impact outside the rubric of platform capitalism.

²<https://www.ssrc.org/programs/just-tech/>

2 PANEL FORMAT

We envision a classic panel format. Panelists will begin with focused, four-minute introductory position statements that express an element of their expertise and address one of the below panel prompts through their experience. In the ensuing moderated conversation, we aim to synthesize among panelists' remarks to address these questions more deeply, and in place panelists in robust conversation with the audience about practical challenges in community divestment.

3 PANEL PROMPTS

- How does the move away from Big Tech platforms reveal elements we have taken for granted as "default" in our study of online interactions [17]? For instance, does a shift from Twitter to Mastodon reveal mistaken underlying assumptions about the nature of social connectivity online?
- How might industry-independence reframe the questions, methods, and functions of CSCW research? How might a shift in audience from corporations to affected communities, regulators, and courts inspire innovations in how we imagine theories of change and work pathways for social computing researchers?
- What hurdles must we address in our funding and legislative ecosystem for the study, maintenance, and continued engagement with independent online communities?
- What are the possibilities for CSCW to address questions of regulation, security, privacy, justice, and governance outside of (or within) corporate-owned systems?
- Big Tech systems are scalable, oriented toward growth, and often enrolled in some form of surveillance capitalism. What can we learn from alternative funding, governance, scale, social responsibility, and temporal models [7], that might trouble the assumptions that undergird today's social technologies?
- What inspiration can we draw for the future of CSCW and the future of social technologies when we look outside the Big Tech frame? Which narratives and sociotechnical imaginaries are commonly left out that we can embrace and build toward instead?

4 INVITED PANELISTS

Laetitia Avia is a lawyer and Senior Fellow at the Center for American Progress where she works on Digital Democracy. She was a member of the French Parliament from 2017 to 2022 and spokeswoman for President Macron's political party. As a MP, she dedicated her work to fighting online harm. She is the author of the French law – known as the "AVIA Bill" – which aims to regulate technology companies and fight online hate speech. She also contributed to the work of the European Commission and the drafting of major EU digital regulation: the Digital Services Act (DSA). She has published several articles and reports on digital abuses, among them a report on digital threats to democracies, with UE MP Sandro Gozi and former Digital Minister Mounir Mahjoubi.

Josh Greenberg is a Program Director at the Alfred P. Sloan Foundation, responsible for both the Technology and New York City programs. He established the Technology program shortly

after joining the Foundation in 2010, and has since developed a portfolio of grantees ranging across data science, data curation, citizen science, scholarly communication, and open source software - including, most recently, a network of open-source program offices at universities and research institutions. A co-founder of Zotero, the first digital strategist for the NY Public Library, and the author of "From Betamax to Blockbuster," Greenberg currently serves on the National Academies' Board on Research Data and Information as well as on the ACLS Commission on Fostering and Sustaining Diverse Digital Scholarship.

Alex Hanna is Director of Research at the Distributed AI Research Institute (DAIR). A sociologist by training, her work centers on the data used in new computational technologies, and the ways in which these data exacerbate racial, gender, and class inequality. She also works in the area of social movements, focusing on the dynamics of anti-racist campus protest in the US and Canada. A former Google employee and a ethical critic of AI, Hanna possesses considerable experience working for change and justice both within and outside of large technology companies, which she brings to this panel conversation.

J Nathan Matias is Assistant Professor of Communication at Cornell University where he leads the Citizens and Technology Lab. He studies digital governance and behavior change in groups and networks shaped by algorithms, and collaborates in citizen behavioral science experiments, working for a world where digital power is guided by evidence and accountable to the public. Matias is also co-founder of the Coalition for Independent Technology Research, which supports, advances, and defends the ecosystem of journalists, community scientists, civil society groups, and academics who independently study technology and society.

Catalina Valejo is the program officer for the Social Science Research Council's Just Tech program. She also supports the Anxieties of Democracy program and the Virtual Research Center on Covid-19 and the Social Sciences. Catalina holds an M.A. and Ph.D. in sociology from the University of Virginia, an M.A. in cultural studies from Universidad de los Andes, and a B.A. in sociology from the Universidad Nacional de Colombia. Her doctoral work focused on post-conflict reparations for victims of armed conflict in Colombia and Peru and was funded by the SSRC and the National Science Foundation. She brings her perspective in technology for justice to the panel.

Janet Vertesi is Associate Professor of Sociology at Princeton University. Vertesi's published research at CSCW focuses on the collaboration practices of NASA spacecraft teams, supported by the National Science Foundation. She is also well known for her "Opt Out Experiments" in evading surveillance capitalism, embracing radical data ownership, and supporting alternative sociotechnical systems that take a stance against data collection and monetization. As an advocate of critical technical practice and anti-racist design practices, and co-editor of the MIT Press Infrastructures series, Vertesi uses her perspective from a decade of practical evasion to reveal the assumptions we have baked into our studies and our systems, and how we might move forward.

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